

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 156

Culture (OWC): [Zulu \(FX20\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1951

Coverage Date: 1800-1951

Place Coverage

Makhanya tribe, Umbumbulu township, Umlazi District, KwaZulu-Natal Province, South Africa

Section Title(S): Brother's Wife—Husband's Brother's Wife

It is between *abazala* that the reciprocal joking relationship (*ukulawula*) formerly obtained, wherein relatives of opposite sexes could take conversational liberties with one another to the extent of insult and indecency. This custom now seems to have disappeared among the Makhanya.

178
[Sociocultural Trends](#)

522
[Humor](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

605
[Cousins](#)

Mother's Sister's Son and Daughter kanina Self-reciprocal

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

The term *kanina* as applied to the mother's sister's children means literally that they are of the same blood as one's mother. The following situation might at first be thought to cause difficulty in the use of the term. Suppose that the great wife of a man bears him only girls, and that in order to have an heir in the great house a sister of that wife is brought in under the custom of sororal substitution. This sister is, however, a widow, and has two boys of her own by the deceased husband. Should not these *okanina* now be called *abafobethu* (brothers) by the daughters of the great house? In practice the widow's children by her former husband must retain that man's *isibongo* (clan name), remain members of his descent group, do not enter the great house of their

587
[Secondary Marriages](#)

593
[Family Relationships](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

605
[Cousins](#)

step-father, and continue to be *okanina* to the daughters of that house, and to any issue of the new union.

614
Clans

The *okanina*, the children of the *mamekazi*, mother's sister, rank for practical purposes in the same degree of closeness as the *abazala*, the children of the *babekazi* or of the *malume*. All the above remarks about *abazala* can be applied to *okanina*, the latter being distinguished by a special term to emphasize that they are children of one's mother's sister, that is, like children of one's own mother. Marriage is prohibited between a man or woman and all four types of cousin: the father's brother's, the father's sister's, the mother's brother's and mother's sister's children. Between father's brother's children, as has been seen, the prohibition is absolute the very notion of the union being regarded with horror. Between relatives who address one another as *kanina* a union can be condoned, as in the case of *abazala*, by the slaughter of a white goat.

582
Regulation Of Marriage

605
Cousins

783
Purification And
Atonement

Marriages between parallel cousins and cross-cousins were traditionally regarded as incestuous because the couples concerned had in common  either their father's or their mother's exogamous patrilineal descent group. The present data show, however, that apart from the close relationship of paternal parallel cousins, cousin marriage 'passing through a woman'—that is, to a father's sister's, mother's brother's or mother's sister's child, is coming no longer to be considered in such a degree of consanguinity as to be incestuous.¹

123
Observation In
Research

582
Regulation Of Marriage

605
Cousins

¹ I was told, nevertheless, that these marriages are still rare. While it was evidently desirable to obtain figures, people are still ashamed of, and do not speak about the relationships obtaining in such marriages. Statistical information on a significant scale would be hard to obtain.

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